

# Identity crises



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**OSes cannot afford to “show-off” the way the gaming industry can**

From the good old 386 days, to the multi-core monsters today, we’ve all watched excitedly as Moore’s law, or interpretations of it, held steadfastly and stubbornly true. It all got crazy about five years ago, when each time we upgraded our hardware, a few months later a friend or acquaintance would outdo us, and have a better rig. But that wasn’t the only irritating bit, what really got on our nerves was that said friend spent way less than us, for something way better. “Ahh, technology!” we’d say, nodding our heads in disappointment, and move on... slowly, thanks to our already outdated machines.

The one industry that is the epitome of this trend is gaming. That’s one area where hardware has been left far behind. As all those of you who have played games like Crysis will testify to, no matter how new your PC is, some games will just bring it to its knees. Some call it future-proofing the game engine, I just call it showing off.

The one vertical that shouldn’t follow that trend, however, is the operating system industry. It’s acceptable to us to have hardware that will not allow us to play the latest games. We’re even fine, for example, with running Adobe’s CS 1 suite instead of the latest CS4. However, it’s not acceptable for an OS to “require” a major hardware upgrade.

Windows 7 launched a little while ago, and of course I’ve been using the pre-release version on one of my non-critical computers for some time now. One stark difference between Vista and 7 that struck me was the performance. I’m not talking about benchmarks on super-high-end hardware that less than 1 per cent of the computing population can afford; I’m talking about the everyday, run-of-the-mill hardware that most of us own. On mid-range configurations, Windows 7 actually seems to do better than Vista. Sure you don’t get to use any of the eye-candy that those with gaming rigs can show off, but at least it works!

I remember people cribbing about the insane (at the time) requirements of XP, and sticking to Windows 98, just to be able to have a usable PC, instead of a good-looking UI that crawled through everyday tasks. It was no different for the switch from XP to Vista, with a lot of people turning their noses up at Vista – me included.

Some say Vista was ahead of its time, and I’m inclined to agree. However, the OS industry cannot afford to do that. OSes cannot afford to “show-off” the way the gaming industry can. I’m not talking just about Microsoft here, because those who use alternates have also

been cribbing about the same bloat. Mac users have complained about sluggish performance, especially irritating when it’s everyday tasks that you’re doing, like searching for files. Even Linus Torvalds himself has complained about bloat in the Linux kernel.

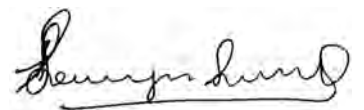
Thankfully, Windows 7 and Apple’s Snow Leopard, both, seem to be a step in the right direction, with reduced bloat, and better optimised code. This is exactly what we need from OSes – to stay light.

Considering that the future is obviously portable, OSes have no choice but to stay light. The lighter the better, in fact, considering that battery technology hasn’t really done anything to speak of in recent times. Portable hardware, in fact, has become more energy efficient to compensate for this, and as a result, slower than the average desktop.

Although we’re all wow-ed by the new looking OSes and all their eye-candy, we should be looking for usability, and functionality. Take for example the whole touch thing.

It’s rumoured that Windows 7 will cause a major shift in device design, with new touch-centric gadgets hogging the spotlight. We’ve heard about all these upcoming “multi-touch” devices, and yet none of them really seem to be exploiting the possibilities that exist. If you don’t believe me, watch Jeff Han’s multi-touch demonstration at TED (<http://tinyurl.com/45jz4a>). I know I’ve spoken of him before, but can you blame me for repeating it, when what we have today, over three and a half years after that demo, is still nowhere close?

I certainly hope OSes get out of the identity crises they’re in, and stick to improving functionality, only, leaving the eye-candy, and the attempt to be everything to everyone on the back-burner. Let the “Ultimate” versions of the OS come with all the bells and whistles, but let’s not stop focusing on the innovations and advances in usability. Enough with our eyes, it’s now time to start designing for the other senses, starting with our fingers. 

  
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